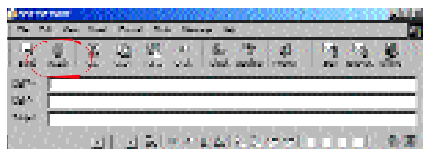


4 Gaffes with attachments

We've all had incidents where we've sent a mail with an attachment, only to send a second mail, sheepishly acknowledging that we'd 'forgotten' to attach the file with the first mail.



Make the 'Attach' icon more prominent so you don't forget to attach the file

Or take the case of this friendly soul, who ended up clogging the mail server when he sent a 10 MB anti-virus program as an attachment to Admin-All. There were some 200 addresses in the list and the server had to generate the attached file for each address. You can do the maths. A waste of bandwidth and time for everybody!

Another example of how attachments can cause a fair amount of heartburn is when you have to download a beautifully formatted document, only to find that the information didn't need to be dressed up with fancy fonts and colours and could very well have been included in the body of the e-mail itself! Forcing someone to download a 100 KB message to read 2 KB of content, especially over a dial-up connection is more than just irritating.



Workaround: Make the 'Attach' icon more prominent in your e-mail client. Right-click the toolbar and click 'Customize'. Now move the 'Attach' icon upwards till it is next to the 'Send' icon on your toolbar. You can also choose 'Show text labels' and 'Large icons' from the 'Text Options' and the 'Icon Options' drop down list, respectively.

Always check the attached file before sending the mail to ensure that you have attached the right file. If your attachment is larger than 100 KB, be kind to the poor chap who'll be downloading it over a dial-up connection and use a compression utility to zip the file.

5 Exposed addresses

It's very easy to send mass e-mails to everyone on the mailing list, but would you want everyone to know who you've sent the mail to? There is no dearth of horror stories of mass e-mails where all the addresses are available to everybody.

Our favourite story is the one where Mr Do-it-all-in-one-shot sent his resume to 10 prospective employers with everyone on the CC list. The damage? He was applying for a middle-level marketing position and he was branded as too clumsy to be relied on to maintain client confidentiality. Needless to say, none of the companies got back to him.



Workaround: It pays to keep in mind certain fundamentals about addressing e-mail:

The 'To:' field: These are the people the e-mail is meant for.

and 'CC:' recipients. This ensures that those you've sent or CC'd the mail to cannot reply to anyone listed in this field. Putting all addresses in the 'BCC:' field is also a great way to ensure that the recipients of the mail will be able to reply only to you. The other advantage is that you won't accidentally be sending off a ready-made list of e-mail addresses that somebody can use for sending spam.

To use 'BCC:', create a group and while e-mailing, send a BCC to the group with your own address in the 'To:' field. To create a group, click on *Address Book > New* and select 'New Group' from the drop down list. Type in the group name and click on 'Select Members'. Now add the addresses you want to the group by selecting the addresses from the left pane and clicking 'Select'. Repeat till you have added everyone you want to the group. Then click 'OK'.

6 Check that forward

Everybody forwards jokes, chain letters, pictures, etc, but what are you forwarding and to whom? Accidentally forwarding a bunch of risqué cartoons and jokes to a special mailing list consisting of your top clients is not quite the right path to career advancement. Also you never know who will find your e-mail funny or interesting enough to forward it on and it's quite possible

that your mail might end up reaching a total stranger's mailbox. There's this infamous story about a woman at Oracle who sent out a bio-data of all her eligible girl friends. The mail was sent to certain eligible bachelors in the office and the purpose was to get dates for her friends for the office Christmas party. This mail did the rounds of the company and finally reached Larry Ellison. Of course, Larry was not too amused about it.



Workaround: There's no sure fire method of preventing your mail from being forwarded to an unknown person, but here's what you can do. Be extremely wary of sending risqué mails to just about any person you know. Make a special group of close friends and send and forward such mails to only these people.

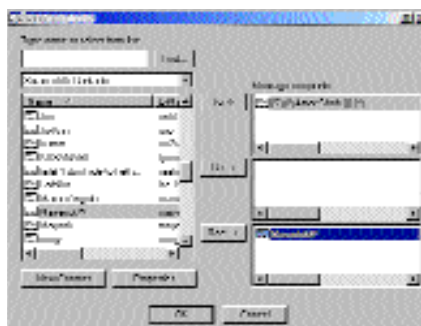
When e-mail comes back to haunt

You've pressed [Shift] + [Delete] and you think that's the end of that compromising e-mail. But it's not that easy to 'kill' e-mail. It could be sitting on your office system server or stored as backup on CDs and DAT tapes. And if someone knows what they are looking for, it would take only a minute for a computer to sort through all the stored messages to find that single incriminating phrase. This is exactly what happened in the Microsoft anti-trust case. The US government was able to get its hands on megabytes of e-mail messages dating from the early 1990s, and Bill Gates's personal e-mail became an exhibit against him.



The 'CC:' field: These are the people you want to keep in the loop of things, but you don't expect them to act on it or respond.

The 'BCC:' field: This is where you put in the addresses of those you want to send the mail to, without revealing their names to the 'To:'



Adding the recipients of your mail to the 'BCC:' field is a great way to ensure that they can only reply back to you